Topic Brainstorming Worksheet
The Topic Map · Multimodal Research Project

Before you gather anything, and before you open any machine, fill the wall. Every topic — a person, a place, an idea — is made of the seven facets below. Under each, list everything you can. Go for quantity now; you'll choose what to keep later.

My topic: the semicolon

People — *who's in it: central figures, witnesses, opponents, the overlooked*
the Italian humanists who invented it; Ben Jonson (1637), who heard in it "somewhat a longer Breath"; Strunk and White, who made it the fix for comma splices; Kurt Vonnegut and Paul Robinson, its fiercest critics; Jennifer DeVere Brody and Ben Dolnick, its defenders; Martin Luther King Jr., whose "Letter from Birmingham Jail" leans on it

Moments — *when it turns: events, first times, last times, daily rituals, turning points*
the ancient Greeks use the mark to ask a question; its first appearance in print, in Pietro Bembo's De Aetna (1494); two Paris law professors fight a duel over semicolon versus colon; a Fall River man is refused a drink at 11:10 p.m. (1900); Boston voters approve a partial repeal of the "Semicolon Law" (1906)

Places — *where it lives: settings, rooms, routes, geographies — the map of it*
Renaissance Italy; a hotel bar in Fall River, Massachusetts; the Massachusetts Supreme Court; Boston restaurants at the 11 p.m. cutoff; the nineteenth-century American schoolroom; a line of computer code (C ends each statement with one)

Objects — *what you can hold: artifacts, tools, products, documents*
the 1875 parchment statute that had a comma where the semicolon later appeared; Lindley Murray's English Grammar (1795); The Chicago Manual of Style, first published in 1906; Joel Cairo's wallet, its contents listed with semicolons in The Maltese Falcon; the ;-) wink

Words — *what's said and written: quotes, sayings, terms, slogans, key texts*
"a pause greater than a comma" (Samuel Johnson); "All they do is show you've been to college" (Kurt Vonnegut); "the agent of reflection and meditation" (The Times, 1943); "a wimpy period" (Merrill Perlman); "semicolon boy," Mayor LaGuardia's insult for Ivy Leaguers; comma splice

Questions — *what's unsettled: the debates, the tensions, the unknowns, the why-it-matters*
Does a semicolon mean anything, or is it decoration? Does using one mark you as educated, or as a snob? Should a law turn on a punctuation mark? Who sets the rules: logic, taste, or the stylebook? Is the semicolon dying, and are the telegraph and the internet to blame?

Numbers — *what can be counted: dates, quantities, statistics, patterns, scale*
1494; a 1737 guide: pause for a count of one at a comma, two at a semicolon, three at a colon, four at a period; 548 grammar books in Goold Brown's 1851 survey; about 2 percent of punctuation marks in late-1900s American writing; a 21-to-10 senate vote that kept the Semicolon Law (1901); two moments with semicolons in all of The Maltese Falcon

Sample built from Wayne Glausser, "What Do Semicolons Mean?" Style 53, no. 3 (2019), and Cecelia Watson, "Points of Contention," Critical Inquiry 38, no. 3 (2012).

Two things to do with your full wall

1. Every facet is a genre waiting to happen. Circle a few items and note the form each could become:

Facet	forms it suggests
People	a monologue, an interview, a character sketch
Moments	a scene, a vignette, a "you-are-there" narrative
Places	a description, a map, a walking tour
Objects	the object as a genre — a recipe, a label, a letter
Words	a found poem, a glossary, an etymology
Questions	an essay, a staged debate, an op-ed
Numbers	an infographic, a chart, a data-song

2. Check your evidence — the three rings. For your strongest items, mark where the evidence sits. A project built only from the outer ring reads as generic; make sure you have real witnesses and traces, not just context.

- **Witness** — someone who knows it firsthand (an interview you conduct). Closest, most specific.
- **Trace** — the documentary record (obituary, article, lyrics, label, letter).
- **Context** — the background world (the history of the place and the era).

A filled example — "my grandmother"

Facet	brainstormed
People	her; my mom (her daughter); her sister; a coworker from the mill
Moments	her wedding; the crossing from Poland; the Sunday dinners; the day she died
Places	her kitchen; the old country; St. Mary's church; the mill town
Objects	her pierogi recipe card; a bundle of letters; the wedding photo; her rosary
Words	"measure with your hands, not a cup"; the obituary; a line from a letter
Questions	what did she leave behind to come here? what did I never think to ask?
Numbers	born 1931; four children; 4,600 miles; 61 years in one house

Witnesses: my mom, her sister (interviews I record). Traces: the obituary, the letters, the photo. Context: the history of her town and the years she lived. The machine can hand me the context in seconds; only I can gather the witnesses and traces — and that's where the project lives.